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KARUNANIDHI HAS CONVEYED HIS DISPLEASURE TO SONIA

in Parliament. Existing operators say the spectrum should have been auctioned but are silent on their own escape through the National Telecom Policy (NTP) 1999 when the government waived dues of an estimated Rs 50,000 crore across 15 years in licence fees and shifted to a viable revenue sharing system. The licence entitles a player for only 4.4 MHz but between 2001 and 2003, operators were granted additional 2.2MHz without any clearance. Ironically, it is Raja who raised the issue of pricing the additional spectrum and his request for an appropriate pricing formula for additional spectrum is being worked out by TRAI. Enraged that he has been charged with allotting spectrum cheaply, Raja has written to the prime minister and the CBI asking for the scope of the investigations to include allotment of additional spectrum since 1999. The Opposition has been quick to paint a scam when the fact is the two biggest changes in the telecom policy—the NTP 99 and the UAS licence

regime—were born during NDA rule in 1999 and 2003, triggering charges of crony capitalism. There is no question that national assets like minerals, land and spectrum need to be priced better. However it has to be consumer-centric; it can't be at the convenience of entrenched interests. The onus is on regulators who have clearly not factored the transfer of public resources to private balance sheets in their calculus.

Curiously, on October 19, two days before the raids, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), examined and allowed the application of Unitech Wireless “to seek approval to enhance foreign shareholding by Telenor Asia, Singapore, such that it may have direct and indirect foreign shareholding of up to 74 per cent. The proposal to the CCEA, which listed the history of Unitech and its licence acquisition, got the clearance of the Home Ministry, the

Department of Revenue in the Finance Ministry, the Ministry of External Affairs (foreign investment unit) and the Department of Policy and Promotion. Significantly, the CCEA didn't find reason to question the investment by Telenor.

“Why” and “why now...” is the question the DMK is asking the Congress, wondering if it is the latest to join the queue of aggrieved allies from the Nationalist Congress to Trinamool Congress. Raja and the DMK are struck by the eerie intersection of speculation about Congress's ambitions in Tamil Nadu and the timing of this action. To be fair to the Congress, this could be just an error, which is what senior Congressmen are telling the DMK supremo. In Delhi, though, the pot of speculation is being stirred with stories of Congress ambitions to put its allies in their place. And every passing event is finding a place in the conspiracy theory—from the environmental clearance to the memorial being built by Mayawati in Noida to the Siliguri snub delivered to Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee and the gory grind that the NCP is being put through in Mumbai. Add the new front in Uttar Pradesh, where the Samajwadi Party is riled by the Congress dynasty's challenge to the Yadav dynasty.

Whatever the reason, the Congress lulled by the lack of Opposition—on the left or right—finds itself in a piquant situation. If indeed there is a Plan B, it has been jeopardised. If it believes in there has been a scam, the Congress should argue for a thorough neutral probe. But if that isn't the case and if the Congress's protestations are true, then a section of the party has hijacked the agenda. The party would do well to remember the 1980s when with over 400 seats it invented an opposition by diving into the corporate Kurukshetra. How else do you explain this inexplicable mess? Why would a regime that has successfully battled issues like Bofors bring upon itself a scam that gives the BJP a lifeline just weeks before Parliament goes into session. ■



“In a democracy, political squabbling goes on, but that does not mean what the Opposition says is always correct.”

**MANMOHAN SINGH,
PRIME MINISTER**